and how would we deal with the flak? Because one thing was certain and for sure: the messengers would be the first to be shot.

It was a US president, Theodore Roosevelt, who pointed to a crucial truth about good governance. ‘Behind the ostensible government sits an invisible government,’ he wrote, ‘owing no allegiance and acknowledging no responsibility to the people. To destroy this invisible government, to befoul this unholy alliance between corrupt business and corrupt politics is the first task of statesmanship.’ Out of all my youthful experience came a certainty about how to do this. It was a certainty in my imagination, at least, and I was now ready to move and make it a progressive reality.

Authoritarian power knows how to strengthen itself through conspiracy, but it came to seem natural to me, logical indeed, that resistance would grow in direction proportion to how much people understood the conspiracy. I am not talking about conspiracy in the sense of secret, one-off cover-ups, the ramblings of tinfoil-hat-wearing weirdos. I am talking about systemic conspiracy, the habitual *modus operandi* for governments who prefer to do everything in secret. Information would set us free. And computer science, as a form of maths, would be our aid in revealing political relationships. Conspirators trust and depend on other conspirators – I have called these dependencies ‘patronage networks’ – and when we stop being hysterical about conspiring parties in society, and become instead rational, we can begin to oppose actions they commit together that they could never commit alone.

And what does a conspiracy compute? It computes the next action of the conspiracy. By the time I was ready to found WikiLeaks, the biggest question for me had become, ‘How can we reduce the power of a conspiracy?’ And the answer seemed within our grasp: to chase their secrets into the open air. I did not invent opposition to these forces: I merely saw that they bred their own opposition, and then tagged them to our new technology. Our job is to stop conspiratorial power from thinking and acting efficiently. And the way to do this, on a global scale, is to open up those conspiracies to the people. We might remember the soothsayer’s advice to Julius Caesar – ‘Security gives way to conspiracy’ – and add a coda of our own: ‘And conspiracy gives way to the people’s power to know it and break its power.’

I should also say something about the role of the technology in all this. The Internet by itself does not give you freedom. The Internet is simply a